LISTENING SKILLS

- Listening is an active process of receiving aural stimuli (De Vito, 1987:26)
- It is the learned process of receiving, interpreting, recalling, evaluating, and responding to verbal and nonverbal messages.
- As humans, we begin to engage with the listening process long before we engage in any recognizable verbal or nonverbal communication.
- Listening is an active, deliberate, selective process by which a message is received, critically interpreted, and acted upon by a purposeful listener.

Listening Vs Hearing

- Understanding the difference between hearing and listening is essential to improve communication skills.
- Hearing is a passive process that does not require any effort or intention. It is like collecting data; we always hear sounds and noises around us.
- It is a passive process; automatic process, and simply the act of perceiving sounds.

- Listening is an active process that involves focusing on the sounds we hear and making sense of them.
- It is a crucial skill that can improve our communication and relationships with others. Listening actively can help us understand others better, avoid misunderstandings, and build stronger relationships.
- While hearing is the physical process of perceiving sound, listening is a psychological process that involves paying attention and making sense of the sounds we hear.

Listening Process

a) **Receiving**

- This is the first step in the listening process, and it involves the physical act of hearing the sound.
- It involves taking in stimuli by our senses. We primarily take in information needed for listening through auditory and visual channels.

b) Attending: After receiving the sound, we must focus on it.

- This consists in filtering out other sounds and distractions and paying attention to the sound we want to listen to

c) Understanding: We must understand the sound once we have attended to it. This involves interpreting the sound and assigning meaning to it.

d) Responding: After we have understood the sound, we may respond to it somehow. This could include asking a question, commenting, or taking other action.

e) Remembering: Finally, we must not forget what we have heard. This involves storing the information in our memory to recall it later.

Types of listening

a) **Informational Listening**

- The process of informational listening focuses on the ability of an individual to understand a speaker's message.
- It is a huge part of everyday life, and failing to understand the concept of informational listening can be very detrimental to one's contribution to society, and to quality of life in general.

- Much of the listening people engage in on a regular basis, falls under the blanket of listening for information.
- For example, in the office, people listen to their superiors for instructions.
- At school, students listen to teachers for information that they are expected to understand for quizzes and tests.
- In all areas of life, informational listening plays a huge role in human communication

b) Reflective Listening

- This is a communication strategy involving two key steps:

i. Seeking to understand a speaker's idea and

ii. Offering the idea back to the speaker, to confirm the idea has been understood correctly.

- Reflective listening attempts to "reconstruct what the client is thinking and feeling and to relay this understanding back to the client".
- Reflective listening is a more specific strategy than the more general methods of active listening.

Subcategories of Types of Listening

a) **Discriminative listening**

- Covers **the conscious reception of all pertinent auditory and visual stimuli**. This may include listening for comprehension where, basic efforts on the **part of the listener is to retain and understand a speaker's message are necessary**.

b) **Critical or evaluative listening**

- Critical or evaluative listening describes situations where the listener makes judgments about the speaker's message.
- As such, critical listening often accompanies (or associated with) persuasive speaking.

- The critical listener attends closely to such matters as speaker and evidence in the message, source credibility (can the source be trusted), the structure of the argument and support for the speaker's arguments.

c) Therapeutic or empathic listening

- Therapeutic listening emphasizes understanding a message from the speaker's perspective in situations where the speaker needs to be heard or talk through an issue.
- In such moments, the listener provides the minimum necessary direction for the speaker's perspective to be clear. Counselling and psychology provide excellent exemplars of this type of listening.

d) Appreciative listening

- Appreciative listening occurs when we listen for enjoyment, aesthetics, or sensory impressions, such as consuming a television sit-com or occupying ourselves with music.

e) Self-listening

- This involves conscious engagement with one's own physical reactions, attitudinal biases and prejudices, or mental markers while listening.
- E.g. focus on the message; concentrate; be positive, etc. Such reflection mostly takes place in one's head, but still requires conscious application of techniques similar to those one would apply while listening to the talk of another person